



Integrated Reform Delivery Plan

Education and Training Sector 2015

DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION AND SKILLS

Education and Training Integrated Reform Delivery Plan 2015

Section 1 Governance

Robust governance arrangements are in place to drive, manage and monitor implementation of the Public Service Reform Plan 2014 to 2016 in the Education and Training sector. A dedicated Programme Management Office (PMO) oversees the development and support the implementation of the Department's Integrated Reform Delivery Plan (IRDP). The office has a full-time Programme Manager and a full-time Shared Services Adviser. The office reports to the Education and Training Reform Board which is chaired by the Secretary General and whose membership comprises members of the Management Advisory Committee (MAC). Appendix 1.

Reform in Early Years settings and Schools

Currently priority school related projects within the IRDP are overseen directly by the Education and Training Reform Board. In addition, a National Implementation Advisory Group, chaired by the Secretary General of the Department, oversees the implementation of the National Literacy and Numeracy Strategy.

Reform in the Further Education and Training Sector (ETB/SOLAS)

A dedicated Project Office manages and co-ordinates reform relating to the Education and Training Boards and SOLAS. A full time programme manager has been assigned at Principal Officer level. The office reports to a high level ETB/SOLAS Programme Board which is chaired by the Secretary General and whose membership comprises the CEO of SOLAS, CEOs from two ETBs, the Secretary General Secretary of Education and Training Boards Ireland, Assistant Secretaries and Principal Officers from across the Department and staff from the Programme Management Office. In addition a Strategy Implementation Advisory Committee (SIAC) chaired by an Assistant Secretary from the Department, has been established by SOLAS to oversee the implementation of the Further Education and Training Strategy.

Reform in the Higher Education and Training Sector

A Programme Board for higher education reform has been established and is chaired by the Deputy Secretary with responsibility for this area. Membership of the Higher Education Programme Board comprises representatives from the Irish Universities Association, Institutes of Technology Ireland and the Dublin Institute of Technology as well as the Assistant Secretary with responsibility for Public Service Reform and Principal Officers from across the Department and staff from the programme management office. In addition a Strategy Implementation Oversight Group (IOG) chaired by the Secretary General has been established to oversee the implementation of the Higher Education Strategy.

Reform in the Department and its Agencies

Priority Projects within the IRDP 2015 relating to the Department and its agencies are overseen directly by the Education and Training Reform Board. Individual projects are overseen by specific project steering groups.

Section 2 Departmental / Sector Specific Reforms

The Minister for Education and Skills is driving the implementation of an ambitious sector wide reform programme, underpinned by the most significant programme of legislative reform undertaken in the Education and Training sector for over a decade. The Department is taking a “whole of system” approach to this reform in the belief that this is the most effective way to deliver meaningful change and better outcomes for all learners. The programme centres on the four key goals of the Department’s Strategy Statement 2015 to 2017:

Learning for Life

We want an education and training system that provides all learners with the knowledge and skills they need to participate fully in society and the economy.

Improving Quality and Accountability

We want to provide for the delivery of a high quality education and training experiences for everyone and improve accountability for educational outcomes across the system.

Supporting Inclusion and Diversity

We want an education and training system that welcomes and meaningfully includes learners with disabilities and special educational needs, learners from disadvantaged communities/backgrounds and those with language, cultural and social differences.

Building the Right Systems and Infrastructure

We want a modern, flexible education and training system which makes the best use of available resources.

The Department is working closely with national agencies and other Government Departments to implement this ambitious programme of reform.

2.1 Departmental/Sector Specific Reform Projects: Learning for Life

2.1.1 Implementation of the Literacy and Numeracy Strategy to 2020

The National Literacy and Numeracy Strategy (2020) drives the implementation of a programme of reform focused on curriculum, assessment and teaching practices to underpin a high quality, relevant learner experience and to enhance learning outcomes in early year’s settings, primary and post-primary schools. Many of the targets set in 2014 for the Strategy were already met ahead of schedule in 2014, and the Minister announced that the interim review of the Strategy, originally planned to take place in 2016 will be brought forward to 2015.

In 2015 the focus of the Literacy and Numeracy Strategy relating to Learning for Life will be on the further implementation of *Aistear*, the curriculum framework for early years education; further reform of the primary and post primary curriculum; the continued monitoring of standards of achievement and practice in schools to ensure implementation of the strategy; and the further development of evaluation in schools. The Interim Review of the Strategy will enable new targets to be set, including targets for sub-groups of students (such as those in DEIS Band 1 schools) where greater improvements in literacy and numeracy standards are required. These targets will be used to measure outcomes resulting from strategy implementation to 2020.

2.1.2 Junior Cycle Reform

The new Junior Cycle is designed to promote, amongst other things, creativity and innovation. It will support learners in learning how to learn, and in taking responsibility for their own learning.

The first phase of Junior Cycle Reform commenced with the introduction of English in September 2014. The replacement of the existing junior certificate and in particular the new focus on assessment poses significant challenges for the Department and the sector. This requires a comprehensive programme of continuing professional development for teachers and principals which is being led by a dedicated team (Junior Cycle for Teachers). The development of the necessary curriculum documents and subject specifications are the responsibility of the NCCA. Implementation of this major reform is subject to intense consultations with the education partners.

2.1.3 Learning for Life reforms in further education and training and in higher education

There are major reform programmes underway in both further education and training and in higher education. Driven by the Department’s vision and the need to invest in people, these reforms will see the implementation of the further education and training strategy and the higher education strategy to improve performance and accountability and provide learners with the opportunities to reach their full potential and contribute to Ireland’s economic, social and cultural development. Learning for Life initiatives for 2015 include the development of a new National Skills Strategy, further roll out of targeted Education and Training initiatives under the **Skills to**

Work brand; enhanced employer engagement and the activation of the Apprenticeship Implementation Plan including a call for proposals from employers and providers leading to the development of apprenticeships in new areas.

2.1.4 Development of a new National Skills Strategy

The development of a new National Skills Strategy will provide a crucial framework for understanding and providing coherent responses to the evolving skills requirements of society and the economy at regional and national level and to ensure that individuals have the right skills to participate fully in society and reach their full potential. This will encompass all levels of the education and training system, with a particular focus on synergies between the higher and further education sectors. It will build on reforms to date, including the development of a strong network of engaged Higher Education Institutions which can meet Ireland's human capital needs across the spectrum of skills areas and a co-ordinated mechanism to engage with industry to ensure alignment of FET with local, regional and national skills demand.

2.1.5 Activation Agenda: Targeted Education and Training Initiatives

As part of the Action Plan for Jobs and Pathways to Work, the Department is continuing to develop high quality education and training to support unemployed people to return to employment by accessing reskilling opportunities appropriate to their needs. The **Skills to Work** brand, developed by Government, represents a coordinated approach to presenting the range of enterprise-focused targeted education and training programmes available to jobseekers. **Skills to Work** includes ICT conversion courses, Springboard, Momentum, Skillnets Jobseeker initiatives, and two programmes from the Department of Social Protection, JobBridge and JobsPlus.

2.1.6 Enhancement of employer engagement

A strategic goal for the Further Education and Training and Higher Education reform programmes is to ensure that the education system meets the spectrum of skills needs to support economic development and job creation. Engagement with employers is key to ensuring that education and training provision is aligned with the needs of the economy and maximises the potential for learners to participate in the labour market.

In line with the actions and deliverables in the FET Implementation Plan and Higher Education Performance Framework, structures to enhance engagement between providers, employers and other stakeholders ensure access to quality labour market intelligence are being examined to ensure the development of the most effective mechanisms for identifying and communicating skills needs at a regional and national level.

In addition as part of the implementation of the FET strategy an assessment of the level of training provision for those in employment will be undertaken to determine where gaps need to be addressed.

2.1.7 Review of Apprenticeship Training

The report of an independent Review Group on apprenticeship training was published in January 2014. The report contains a large number of recommendations for the extension of apprenticeship to new sectors and for modernising the existing apprenticeship system. An apprenticeship Implementation Plan was published in June 2014. New standards and curricula will be developed and rolled out for existing apprenticeships in 2015. In addition, a call for proposals from employers and education and training providers for the development of apprenticeship programmes in new areas is underway, managed by the new Apprenticeship Council. With strong engagement from employers and providers, both the updated and new programmes will enhance the supply of job-ready personnel in key areas as well as providing a strong basis for successful and sustainable careers for young people. Initial work on legislation on longer term governance in the apprenticeship area will also be undertaken in 2015.

2.1.8 Improving transitions and removing barriers to progression between level of education and training

The Department is committed to ensuring learners are provided with more flexible learning options and that they are enabled to move through and across the continuum of education as it suits their education/training needs and requirements through life. In addition a Transition Reform Steering Group has been established to address concerns that the dual use of the leaving Certificate to a) assess second level outcomes and b) to provide the basis for selection and entry into higher education institutions is having negative effects on teaching and learning in post primary schools. Reform is also addressing any problematic predictability in the Leaving Certificate Examinations and work is ongoing to offer broader entry routes into third level through reducing the number of degree programmes in higher education.

2.1 Learning for Life		
	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
2.1.1 National Literacy and Numeracy Strategy Implementation	2.1.1.1 Web based Aistear and Siolta Practice Guide published Q 2 2.1.1.2 Integrated language (Irish and English) curriculum for the first four years of primary school published (implementation September 2016) Q2 2.1.1.3 New primary maths curriculum for first four years of primary school consultation and development underway Q2 2.1.1.4 Review of Senior Cycle subject specifications in the Sciences, Agricultural Science, Economics and Applied Maths underway 2.1.1.5 New Senior Cycle subject specification in Politics and Society in development 2.1.1.6 New foreign Languages in Education Strategy published Q3 2.1.1.7 Report on the analysis of standardised test data returned by primary schools for 2011/2012 and 2012/2013 published Q1 2.1.1.8 Standardised test data from all primary schools returned 2014/2015 Q2 2.1.1.9 Field work in post-primary schools for PISA 2015 (Programme for International Assessment) completed Q1 2.1.1.10 Field work in primary and post-primary schools for TIMSS 2015 (trend in International Maths and Science Study) completed Q2 2.1.1.11 Interim Review of the National Literacy and Numeracy Strategy carried out and new targets set Q4	Early Years Education Section Curriculum and Assessment Unit Inspectorate NCCA Educational Research Centre
2.1.2 Junior Cycle Reform	2.1.2.1 Development of new science curriculum and assessment arrangements for Junior Cycle Q2	Curriculum and Assessment Unit NCCA SEC
2.1.4 National Skills Strategy	2.1.4.1 National Skills Strategy developed, Q3	Higher Education Policy and Skills Section Further Education and Training Section
2.1.5 Activation Agenda: Targeted	2.1.5.1 The second round of the Momentum programme, providing some	Further Education and Training Section Higher Education Policy and Skills

Education and Training Initiatives	6,500 places, will be completed in Q3 A further round of Momentum will be considered as part of budgetary planning. 2.1.5.2 Roll out of Springboard 2015 Q3 2.1.5.3 Roll out ICT graduate skills conversion programmes 2015 Q3	Section SOLAS HEA
2.1.6 Enhancement of employer engagement	2.1.6.1 Employer Engagement Strategy and Action Plan for Higher Education developed Q1 2.1.6.2 Coordination mechanisms for Further Education and Training and Higher Education providers to engage with industry at national, regional and local level to ensure alignment of provision to skills requirements, reviewed Q1 2.1.6.3 Training provision for those in employment assessed and gaps identified Q4	Higher Education Policy and Skills Section Further Education and Training Section SOLAS HEA
2.1.7 Review of Apprenticeship Training	2.1.7.1 Proposals for apprenticeships in areas outside of current trades received Q1 2.1.7.2 Report with recommendations on viable new Apprenticeships submitted to the Minister Q3 2.1.7.3 Apprenticeship Bill work on Heads of Bill completed Q4	Further Education and Training Section SOLAS
2.1.8 Improving transitions and removing barriers to progression between level of education and training	2.1.8 Implementation Plan for the reform of the transition between second level and higher education published Q2	Higher Education Policy and Skills Section

2.2 Departmental/Sector Specific Reform Projects: Improving Quality and Accountability

2.2.1 Early Years sector

The Department is working closely with the Department of Children and Youth Affairs on quality improvement within the early-years sector. It will support the operation of Better Start the newly established quality support service for the sector which will deploy a team of early year's specialists as mentors/advisers working with early-years services on quality improvement. During 2015, the NCCA will publish a web-based *Aistear and Siolta Practice Guide* which will host a range of interactive resources and materials in support of quality in practice. A new Early Years Education Advisory Group will be established.

To complement the work of the Child and Family Agency pre-school inspectorate (TUSLA), the DES Inspectorate is planning for the introduction of focused inspections on the quality of educational provision in early childhood education settings participating in the Free Pre-School Year Programme.

2.2.2 Increasing autonomy and accountability of schools

The Programme for Government includes commitments to devolve greater autonomy to schools. A consultation exercise will precede the development of firm policy proposals to grant greater autonomy to schools, while ensuring that proper accountability mechanisms are in place, and this is currently under consideration in the Department.

2.2.3 Implementation of new School self-evaluation (SSE) model and roll out of new models of school inspection in all schools

The Department continues to roll out the new self-evaluation model for all primary and post-primary schools. The new self-evaluation model articulates a clear set of standards for schools and focuses on outcomes for the learner, the objective of which is to enable school improvement. Work in 2015 will focus on supporting schools to use the criteria provided in the SSE Guidelines to determine where improvements are needed and to set realistic and measurable targets to improve pupil/student learning. It will also focus on ensuring that schools provide meaningful short summaries of their SSE reports and school improvement plans to their school communities. Preparation of criteria to assist schools to engage in SSE of leadership and management, in consultation with relevant partners will also be undertaken.

The roll out of a new range of inspection models for all schools will continue in 2015. These new inspection models increase the efficiency and effectiveness of inspection and they support the targeting of resources where the need for assistance and support is greatest. Work in 2015 will focus on continuing to implement a comprehensive programme of evaluation using a range of new and recently reformed inspection models, revising supporting guidelines and regulations, and developing and piloting new elements relating to curriculum evaluation, student wellbeing and the inspection of special education provision.

2.2.4 Gaeltacht Education Review

As part of its work to support the implementation of the 20-Year Strategy for Irish, the Department commenced a major review of education provision in the Gaeltacht in 2014 and this work will be advanced in 2015. It is planned that the current research phase of the work will conclude and that policy options to improve education provision in Gaeltacht areas will be developed.

2.2.5 Implement the FET Strategy and new governance arrangements for the Further Education and Training Sector including SOLAS

SOLAS was established in 2013 to oversee the operation of the Further Education and Training sector. A five year Further Education and Training Strategy and related implementation plan was published in 2014 which identifies key objectives and targets for the sector. As the new oversight and funding agency SOLAS will play a key role in relation to quality and accountability within the Further Education and Training Sector. A new funding model based on performance levels will be implemented through the agreement of annual Further Education and training Service Plans with the ETBs. The first Service Plan was published for 2014 and the model is being further developed and improved for 2015 and subsequent years.

2.2.6 Introducing a Systems Performance Framework for Higher Education provision

Implementation of the Higher Education Strategy is ongoing and involves the development of a new system of governance and a new performance framework to increase accountability of autonomous higher education institutions for public funding and performance against national priorities.

A National Framework for PhD Education has been developed by the HEA/QQI in consultation with a number of stakeholders. It commits the stakeholders to the highest standards in the provision of doctoral education and research so that students, employers, etc may have full confidence in the quality of Irish doctoral education.

Work in this area comes under the governance of a Strategy Implementation Oversight Group (IOG) chaired by the Secretary General.

2.2.7 Enhancing teaching in Education

To ensure that early year's practitioners are equipped with the skills and competences to work in the early year's sector, DES will be carrying out a review of education and training programmes that lead to qualifications in early years care and education. The consultation process for the review will be launched in January 2015.

As part of the ongoing progression towards a fully regulated teaching body within the framework of the Teaching Council Acts changes have been made to the content and pedagogical approaches included in Initial Teacher Education (ITE) programmes to prepare teachers better for the classroom and a number of ITE programmes for the Further Education and Training sector have been accredited. Plans are in place to commence Part 5 of the Teaching Council Act (Fitness to Teach) following amendments to the Act to strengthen provision in this area and to provide for Garda Vetting arrangements. The Council will continue to progress the quality agenda for teaching in 2015 through further work on the review of entry criteria for initial teacher education programmes, the development of induction and probation procedures and progression towards a framework for CPD.

Work by the Department on the digital strategy for schools (see section 3.2 Digital Government/ICT) is aimed at maximizing the use of digital technologies to transform teaching, learning and assessment at primary and post primary level.

Some initial work will also be undertaken by SOLAS in 2015 on profiling the skills base in ETBs to inform the development of a CPD Strategy for ETB staff involved in the delivery of further education and training programmes.

The National Forum for the Enhancement of Teaching and Learning is the key system-level infrastructure for the enhancement of teaching and learning in Irish higher education. The National Forum is engaged in a range of activities aimed at providing all students with the highest quality teaching and learning experience. Work in 2015 will see the introduction of a professional development framework for teachers in higher education which will drive initiatives in the areas of academic professional development and flexible provision. In addition a roadmap for the integration of technology in teaching in higher education will be developed.

2.2.8 Enhancing School Leadership

The Department has engaged with IPPN (Irish Primary Principals Network), NAPD (National Association of Principals and Deputy Principals) and PDST (Professional Development Services for Teachers) in taking a more strategic approach to the development of leadership skills among new and long serving Principals and will progress proposals for the development of a coherent continuum of professional development for school leaders in 2015. It is expected that an announcement will be made in Q1 in this regard.

2.2.9 International Education

A review of Investing in Global Relationships: Ireland's International Education Strategy 2010 - 2015 will be undertaken in 2015 to support the development of a new Government action plan for the promotion of Ireland as a center for international education.

The International Education Mark (IEM) was proposed in Ireland's International Education Strategy 2010 – 2015 as a means of enhancing the quality and promotion of international education in Ireland. QQI is responsible for authorising use of the IEM by providers of programmes of education and training. The IEM confirms that a provider has demonstrated their capacity and commitment to provide a high-quality educational experience to international students.

The final Code of Practice Policy for Providers of Programmes of Education and Training to International Students will be proposed for adoption by the Board of QQI in Q1 2015. QQI will begin to accept applications for authorisation to use the IEM from English Language Training Organisations in mid-2015 and higher education providers will then be able to apply in the second half of the year.

2.2 Improving Quality and Accountability		
	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
2.2.1 Quality in Early Years	2.2.1.1 Early year's educational inspections active Q3 2.2.1.2 Educational inspection for early years, reports published Q4	Inspectorate
2.2.2 Increasing autonomy and accountability of schools	2.2.2.1 Proposals for consultation process on increasing the autonomy and accountability of our schools developed	Central Policy Unit Inspectorate
2.2.3 Implementation of new School self-evaluation (SSE) model and roll out of new models of school inspection in all schools.	2.2.3.1 Criteria for SSE of leadership and management developed in consultation with relevant partners Q4 2.2.3.2 Pilot evaluations conducted under new inspection models commenced Q1 2.2.3.3 A collaborative research project with a number of primary and post-primary schools on how schools provide for students' wellbeing commenced in December 2014. An interim research report will be available in Q4	Inspectorate

	2.2.3.4 The revised Inspectorate's Code of Practice, Regulations governing publication of inspection reports and related guidelines will be published Q2	
2.2.4 Gaeltacht Education Review	2.2.4.1 Four research studies on education provision in Gaeltacht schools completed Q1 2.2.4.2 Draft policy paper for consultation on future development of education in Gaeltacht prepared Q2 2.2.4.3 Undertake consultation on policy paper (subject to agreement of the Department of Arts, Heritage and the Gaeltacht and Cabinet Committee)	Curriculum and Assessment Unit Inspectorate
2.2.5 Implement the FET Strategy and new governance arrangements for the Further Education and Training Sector (SOLAS)	2.2.5.1 Further Education and Training Services Plan (performance funding) 2015 agreed with ETBs and published Q2 2.2.5.2 Effectiveness and delivery of Post Leaving Certificate (PLC) Programmes reviewed Q4	Further Education and Training Section SOLAS
2.2.6 Introducing a Systems Performance Framework for Higher Education provision	2.2.6.1 Strategic dialogue 2015 resulting in revised compacts with the HEIs Q2 2.2.6.2 System Performance Report 2014 published Q2 2.2.6.3 Promotion of the Framework for PhD Education with individual Higher Education Institutions undertaken	Higher Education Policy and Skills Section HEA QQI
2.2.7 Enhancing teaching in Education	2.2.7.1 Draft review of education and training programmes that lead to qualifications in early years care and education (ECCE) available Q4 2.2.7.2 Initial consultation on continuing Professional development framework for teachers completed by the Teaching Council (phase 1 end Q1) 2.2.7.3 Teaching Council Amendment Bill published (pending response from Government Legislative Committee) Q1 2.2.7.4 Fitness to practice procedures for teachers commenced Q3 2.2.7.5 Consideration of research advice from the Teacher Council on changes to ITE courses (entry criteria) Q4 2.2.7.6 Strategy on Guidance in FET complete Q3 2.2.7.7 Professional development framework for teachers in higher education introduced Q4	Early Years Education Section Curriculum and Assessment Unit Further Education and Training Section Higher Education Research and Funding Section Teaching Council SOLAS National Forum for the Enhancement of Teaching & Learning in Higher Education

2.2.8 Enhancing School Leadership	2.2.8.1 Outline policy for developing and supporting school leadership announced Q1	Teacher Education Section
2.2.9 International Education	2.2.9.1 Ireland's International Education Strategy 2010- 2015 reviewed Q2 2.2.9.2 New Action Plan for International Education published Q4 2.2.9.3 Policy and Code of Practice relating to the International Education Mark (IEM)Published Q1 2.2.9.4 Application process, to use the International Education Mark (IEM), open for English Language Training Providers Q2	International Section QQI

2.3 Departmental/Sector Specific Reform Projects: Supporting Inclusion and Diversity

2.3.1 Reform of school practice

2.3.1.1 Enrolment: Consultation is underway to ensure that the process of enrolling children in schools is more open, equitable and consistent. Legislative proposals have been published and a Draft Bill has been considered by the Oireachtas committee. Subject to Government decisions, it is expected that the Education (Admission to School) Bill will proceed to publication and enactment in 2015. Prior to commencing the legislation, the Department will consider whether it is necessary to give a lead-in period for schools to update their enrolment policies and practices so as to facilitate a smooth transition to the statutory requirements.

2.3.1.2 Parent and Student Engagement: The Minister has committed to publishing the arrangements for establishing a Parent and Student Charter. The purpose of the Charter is to strengthen the position of parents within the school system and to bring about a culture change in how schools engage with and involve parents (and students in an age related manner).

2.3.2 Increasing choice of primary school type

The Department is committed to providing for greater diversity of school type and to implementing a planning approach that has a greater emphasis on parental preferences. During 2015 the Department will continue to support the process of divesting of Catholic primary schools in 28 areas. Work in 2015 will focus on advancing identified options for alternative patronage provision.

2.3.3 Promoting inclusiveness in schools

Following the publication in July 2014 of *Forum on Patronage and Pluralism in the Primary Sector: Progress to Date and Future Directions*, work will continue in association with primary school patron bodies to disseminate good practice and to encourage greater inclusivity in schools. Work will continue on the development of a curriculum in Education about Religion and Beliefs and Ethics in 2015.

New inspection models will evaluate and report on the quality of education provision for marginalised learners and learners with special education needs during 2015.

2.3.4 New allocation model for special needs teaching resources

A new model for the allocation of resource and learning support teachers for all mainstream primary and post primary schools will be developed and proposals for its implementation will be submitted to Government for decision.

2.3.5 Widening participation in higher education

A new National Access Plan for higher education will be developed to promote access for disadvantaged groups and to put in place coherent pathways from second level education, from further education and other non-traditional entry routes with the objective of progressing towards the Bologna Process objective of ensuring that the student body entering, participating in and completing higher education at all levels reflects the diversity of Ireland's population.

2.3.6 Developing a life-course approach to social inclusion in education

The Department has commenced work on the development of a more strategic approach to social inclusion across the continuum of education. In 2015 this work will focus on a mapping and analysis of current policies and programmes and the preparation of a policy document to direct future provision in this area.

2.3: Supporting Inclusion and Diversity		
	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
2.3.1 Reform of school practice	2.3.1.1 Education (Admission to School) Bill published Q2 2.3.1.2 Parent and Student Charter underpinning principles published Q2	School Governance Section
2.3.2 Increasing Choice of Primary School Type	2.3.2.1 Build on progress towards increasing diversity of school type	Planning and Building Unit
2.3.3 Promoting inclusiveness in schools	2.3.3.1 Promotion of better practices in schools in relation to inclusivity Q2 2.3.3.2 Final consultation report on development of a curriculum in Education about Religion and Beliefs and Ethics Q4 2.3.3.3 Quality of education provision in mainstream settings for learners with special education needs evaluated and reported on through the development of a new inspection model. The model will be piloted from Q3	Curriculum and Assessment Unit Central Policy Unit Inspectorate
2.3.4 New allocation model for special needs teaching resources	2.3.4.1 Proposal for new allocation model for special needs teaching resources developed Q1	Special Education Section
2.3.5 Widening participation in higher education	2.3.5.1 National Access Plan for Higher Education launched Q2	Higher Education Equity of Access and Qualifications Section HEA
2.3.6 Developing a life-course approach to social inclusion in education	2.3.6.1 Paper on life-course approach to Social Inclusion in Education completed Q4	Social Inclusion Section

2.4 Departmental/Sector Specific Reform Projects: Building the right systems and infrastructure

2.4.1 Roll out of the Five Year School Building Programme

The Department is committed to ensuring an appropriate supply of education infrastructure to meet demographic demand and providing high quality replacement accommodation. The 2bn five-year capital investment programme currently being implemented by the Department includes the allocation of €1.5bn for the period 2012 to 2015 towards 275 new large scale building projects announced in March 2012 and a further 44 large scale building projects announced since including projects published under the Governments Stimulus programme. By the end 2014, a total of 274 of the 319 major projects had been given approval to proceed under the annual programme announcements.

25,000 permanent school places, 19,000 of which are additional places will be delivered through completions under the large scale project programme and the devolved additional accommodation scheme in 2015. It is projected that up to 50 large scale projects will be substantially completed in 2015. The capital allocation for 2015 is €450 million in respect of the primary and post-primary sectors, with a projected expenditure on large scale projects of over €280 million.

2.4.2 Development of a teacher supply forecasting mechanism

There is a need to develop a sustainable model relating to teacher supply to ensure the system is prepared for demographic changes and to meet the changing requirements of society and the labour market. A technical working group has been established by the Teaching Council with representatives from key stakeholder groups to develop and pilot a model of teacher supply. A report on the work of this group is due at the end of 2015.

2.4.3 Roll out of the Primary Online Database (POD)

The new online database for primary school data (POD) has been developed to monitor the education progress of learners in primary school (in DES aided schools) throughout the primary system and onwards to post primary level to facilitate and support learners to develop their full educational potential. The online system once fully operational will also become the basis for the allocation of teachers and capitation grants to schools. POD will provide information for schools and the Department which will inform policy through statistical analysis and evaluation.

2.4.4 Structural Reform in Further Education and Training

33 VECs have been replaced by the establishment of 16 Education and Training Boards. In 2015 work will focus on embedding these new structures through the formulation of a new organisation design for ETBs/SOLAS which will reflect their new roles and the development of an associated migration plan. Work will continue in supporting people and enhancing communication arising from the establishment of ETBs and the merger with training centres. The final phase of staff transfers which will see arrangements in place for ETBs not receiving training centres will take place during 2015. Key shared service projects in this sector will also be rolled-out in accordance with the implementation of the Department's Shared Services Plan.

2.4.5 Further Education and Training Data

There is a critical need to improve the availability of detailed information on the involvement and experience of learners accessing further education and training interventions and on the courses provided through further education and training interventions. SOLAS is working on three elements of a new data system to connect ETBs, SOLAS and Intreo Offices including a national course database, a national course calendar and a national learner database. SOLAS is progressing these projects in collaboration with a representative group of departments and other stakeholders. The resulting information will be used to support policy development, inform programme planning to ensure we meet labour market demands and will provide a platform to facilitate reporting on FET provision in the future.

2.4.6 Structural Reform in Higher Education

Implementation of key aspects of the higher education landscape reform process will continue to roll out during 2015. The Technological Universities Bill is to be published in Q2, 2015 (subject to response from the Government Legislative Committee). It provides the legal underpinning for the mergers of Institutes of Technology, the establishment of Technological Universities and the reform of governing bodies in the Institutes of Technology. Work will also continue through the HEA to further develop the mechanisms and structures for regional planning and to enable clustering of HEIs.

An Expert Group has been established to make recommendations on the future funding of higher education and this group is due to report by the end of the year.

2.4.7 Centralisation of student grants function and further roll out of new online student grant application system, SUSI

The new single on-line student grant application system will, following the current transition period, reduce the number of grant awarding bodies from sixty-six to one. It provides students with a single point of contact and is a more cost efficient and effective service delivery channel, introducing extensive electronic information sharing between Government Departments and public bodies to simplify the application process. It also reforms the payment system for students, introducing monthly electronic payments directly to students' bank accounts. The system is progressively taking on all new grant applications and annual grant renewals.

2.4.8 Improving our capacity in relation to data management, data analytics, research and evaluation

The Department aims to maximise the use of data and enhance our analytical and research capacity to support the development and evaluation of policies and service delivery. A scoping exercise to determine the best approach to achieve this was completed in 2014 and a course of action in relation to data management, research and evaluation capacity was proposed and accepted. An implementation plan outlining specific actions

and associated timelines will be developed in Q1 2015. Activity in these inter-related areas will be overseen by the Data, Evaluation & Research MAC sub-committee (DERMS).

2.4 Building the right systems and infrastructure		
	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
2.4.1 Roll out of the Five Year School Building Programme	2.4.1.1 50 large scale building projects substantially completed Q4	Planning and Building Unit
2.4.2 Development of a teacher supply forecasting mechanism	2.4.2.1 Interim report of the technical working group on teacher supply being considered Q1 2.4.2.2 Final report of the technical working group on teacher supply forecasting being considered Q4	Teacher Education Section Teaching Council
2.4.3 Roll out of the Primary Online Database POD	2.4.3.1 Testing of POD capability for teacher and capitation grant allocation for primary schools commenced Q3	Statistics Section
2.4.4 Structural Reform in Further Education and Training	2.4.4.1 Arrangements to enable all ETBs to meet their statutory commitments to delivery training, in place, through phase 3 transfer of staff (non-training centre ETBs) Q3 2.4.4.2 Organisational Design for ETBs finalised Q1 2.4.4.3 ETB ICT Strategy developed Q3 2.4.4.4 Plan for future management of transitional supports agreed Q1 2.4.4.5 ICT connectivity in ETBs improved through connection to Government Networks Q2	Further Education and Training Section ETB/SOLAS Project Management Office CEO's of ETB's
2.4.5 Further Education and Training Data	2.4.5.1 National programme database ready for use Q3 2.4.5.2 National programme calendar (PLSS) ready for use Q3	Further Education and Training Section SOLAS
2.4.6 Structural Reform in Higher Education	2.4.6.1 Consultation paper on future funding policy for higher education published and disseminated Q1 2.4.6.2 Report on Future funding policy for higher education submitted to the Minister Q4 2.4.6.3 Technological Universities Bill published Q2 2.4.6.4 Centres of Excellence for Teacher Education: Phase 1 of DCU Incorporation Project with registration of first year	Higher Education Policy and Skills Section Teacher Education Section HEA

	undergraduates (St Patrick's College, Drumcondra and Mater Dei Institute) as DCU students Q3 2.4.6.5 Higher Education Governance Bill Heads of Bill developed Q1	
2.4.7 Improving our capacity in relation to data management, research and evaluation	2.4.7.1 Implementation plan to improve our capacity in relation to data management, research and evaluation agreed Q1	Statistics Section

Section 3: Cross Cutting Reforms

3.1 Improved Service Delivery/Customer Service

The Department will undertake a range of initiatives to improve direct service delivery in 2015 including further development and rollout of new ICT systems which will help to reduce the administrative burden on schools, improve service delivery to school employees and increased use of online communications channels including social media to communicate with stakeholders and the general public. Work will also be advanced on the development of a new Customer Charter and Action plan which will restate the Department's commitment to the delivery of high quality services to all customers and which will outline the standards of service that customers can expect when they interact with the Department by phone, in writing or in person.

In addition a range of sector related reforms outlined in Section 2 above aim to improve service delivery directly and indirectly through agencies, schools, institutions etc. They include work on the reform of school enrolment practice and associated legislative change, reforms in further education and training and in higher education and communication activity associated with the comprehensive programme of change.

	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
Pensions modeller for school employees	Department's Pensions Modeller will "go live" in Q2	Pensions Section
Customer Charter and Action Plan	Customer Charter and Action Plan published Q1	Corporate Services

3.2 Digital Government / ICT

During 2015 the Department will continue to improve data collection to develop a stronger basis for long term thinking and strategic decision making. The Department will work closely with the OGCI0 to implement the ICT strategy for the Public Service, due to be published in early 2015, subject to availability of resources and finalise its ICT Strategy for 2015-2019. The potential use of the new Cloud Service Catalogue, being developed by the OGCI0, will be considered for shared services and IT developments. Initiatives being undertaken by the Department are underpinned by a positive approach to digitalisation including the development of a digital strategy for schools, the continued roll out and implementation of POD, further enhancements to P-POD and SUSI, development of a mobile application for inspectors to collate data in the course of inspections, work on the development of course and calendar databases in FET.

The Department is developing a Digital Strategy for Schools which will set out a five year programme to maximise the use of digital technologies to transform teaching, learning and assessment at primary and post primary level. This strategy will contain actions that will facilitate schools and teachers in adapting new pedagogies and engaging with students using ICT in a seamless way in teaching, learning and assessment.

	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
Developing a Digital Strategy for Schools	Publication of the Digital Strategy for Schools Q1	ICT Policy Section

3.3 Shared Services

The DES has developed a comprehensive Shared Services Plan for the Education and Training sector for the period 2014 – 2016. The plan includes projects at all levels of the sector including schools, Education and Training Boards, Higher Education and the Department and agencies. Key priorities in 2015 include:

Project	Milestones 2015	2015 Investment	Section/Agency Responsible
Payroll Shared Services ETBs	ETB, Payroll Shared Services Designed and Developed Q3 ETB, Payroll Shared Service implementation commenced Q4	3.76m	ETB/SOLAS Project Management Office

Payroll Shared Services Higher Education	Higher Education Payroll Shared Services Business Case developed Q2 Decision to progress development of Higher Education Payroll dependent on outcome of business case Q4	0.8m	Higher Education Research and Funding Section
Financial Management Shared Service ETBs	ETB, Financial Management Shared Service, baseline and business case complete Q3 Decision to progress development of ETB Financial Management Shared Service dependent on outcome of business case Q4	1.85m	ETB/SOLAS Project Management Office
Financial Management Shared Service Higher Education	Financial Management Shared Service Higher Education baseline complete Q4	0.06m	Higher Education Research and Funding Section
SUSI ICT upgrade	Upgrade to SUSI ICT Platform - requirements gathering complete Q4	0.25m	Higher Education Equity of Access and Qualifications Section CDETB
DES, SEC and NCCA staff migration to Civil Service Payroll Shared Service	DES, SEC and NCCA staff migrated to Civil Service Payroll Shared Service Q1 (Wave 3)		Finance Unit
Pensions Shared Services	Business Case for Pensions Shared Service in the Education Sector Q4	0.08m	Finance Unit
Teachers Payroll upgrade for Shared Services	Review of the current Teachers payroll to establish the upgrades required for Shared Services Q4	0.05m	Payroll Section

3.4 External Service Delivery

The Department has prepared an External Service Delivery (ESD) Plan and during 2014 a number of areas were assessed for suitability for external service delivery including the administration of inspection questionnaires for parents and students in schools, electronic payments in schools and the assistive technology scheme. The feasibility of outsourcing facilities management functions in the sector, where this has not been done already, is also being assessed. The ESD Plan 2014 – 2016 will be reviewed in quarter two of 2015.

	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
Inspectorate Questionnaires	Proceed to implementation phase of Inspectorate Questionnaires, pending outcome of the business case, Q1	Inspectorate Public Service Reform Programme Office
Facilities Management Services	Report on priority areas for outsourcing of facilities management services complete Q2	Public Service Reform Programme Office
Payments in Schools	Proposal re. online payment system solution for schools complete Q1 Recommendation re. online payment system solution for schools disseminated Q2	Public Service Reform Programme Office

Assistive technology scheme	Report on potential to outsource the assistive technology scheme Q4	Public Service Reform Programme Office
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3.5 Public Procurement

The DES and organisations in the wider Education and Training sector are actively engaged in supporting the implementation of the Procurement Reform Programme, including the establishment of the Office for Government Procurement (OGP) and associated structures. This work will continue throughout 2015. In 2014 the Education Procurement Service (EPS) was established as a sector wide Education HUB. EPS procures sector specific goods/services on behalf of the sector and manages two categories on behalf of the OGP under the hub and spokes model. Work is underway to develop a strategy for the Education HUB and to ensure that the HUB is appropriately resourced to deliver on that strategy. In addition to this, a Schools Procurement Unit has been established to support the schools sector and assist them in their engagement and compliance with the new centralised procurement model.

3.6 Property Management

The Department participates on the steering group for Property Asset Management in the implementation of the Property Reform Programme. In keeping with the objectives of the Property Reform Programme the Department has recently rationalised accommodation in six locations and will continue to work with the Office of Public Works on further projects to be undertaken in 2015 to improve efficient space utilisation. All offices occupied by staff of the Department and the name and location of all school property in the ownership of the Minister have been registered on the OPW property management system. Further work is underway to map property occupied by Education and Training Boards. The information is being gathered through a detailed survey, the results of which are expected to be available in early 2015. Work is underway within the department to document and map properties on a common database in the sector.

	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
ETB Property Portfolio	Compilation of ETB Property Portfolio complete Q2	ETB/SOLAS Project Management Office
Education Sector Property database	Education Sector Property database design and development commenced Q2	Corporate Services

3.7 Public Expenditure Reform and Organisational Performance

A comprehensive review of Current Expenditure and a review of Capital Investment Framework were undertaken by the Department in 2014 in accordance with the timescale set out by the Department of Public Expenditure and Reform. These reviews inform the determination by Government of current expenditure ceilings for the period 2015 to 2017 and the capital framework up to 2020. A number of business process improvement (BPI) projects have now been undertaken in the Department and these will be evaluated and reviewed in 2015 with a view to identifying other areas which would benefit from BPI initiatives. Work on preparing the Department, the SEC and the NCSE to migrate to the Public Sector Financial Management Shared Service Centre will continue during 2015. The Department is also further developing its programme and project governance processes for reform projects which includes tracking and reporting templates and methodologies for managing risks and issues. A benefits realisation process will be developed and piloted during 2015. Other work in this area includes the development of the Department's Strategy Statement for 2015 to 2018 and the further development of performance level agreements with a number of agencies.

	Milestones 2015	Section/Agency Responsible
Strategy Statement	Department's Statement of Strategy 2015 to 2017 published Q1	Corporate Services
Business Process Improvement	Evaluation of Business Process Improvement complete Q1	Human Resources

Public Sector Financial Shared Services Centre	Activation of Purchasing Module on DES FMS system on phased basis between Q2 and Q4 (required to enable migration of DES to shared financials platform as part of Wave 3 migration, currently scheduled for second half of 2017)	Finance Unit
Benefits Realisation	Department process for identifying and monitoring benefits realisation piloted Q3	Public Service Reform Programme Office

3.8 Leadership Development and HR Reforms

The Department will participate in the civil and public sector wide reform initiatives being led by the Department of Public Expenditure and Reform including implementation of the learning and development shared services project, continuous improvement of performance management development system, supporting succession planning including cascading Senior Public Service (SPS) coaching and senior management programmes for future leaders.

3.9 Increased Openness, Transparency and Accountability

A range of initiatives and projects are planned to increase openness, transparency and accountability across the Education and Training Sector. These are included in section 2 and include improved inspection arrangements in schools, school self-evaluation and reporting, the Department's participation in IrelandStat, the implementation of the Higher Education Performance Framework as part of the Higher Education Strategy. The Department is establishing a MAC Committee to support effective discharge of its oversight and compliance function with regard to agencies under its remit. In this context, the MAC Committee will consider the further standardisation, to a high level, of the Department's approach to managing governance, including the formal review and measurement of performance of agencies and the dissemination of best practice

3.10 Civil Service Renewal Plan implementation

The Department is committed to the implementation of the Civil Service Renewal Plan and will participate fully in the transformation programme to build capacity and capability to meet the challenges of the future and to make sure that renewal becomes a reality.

Section 4 Haddington Road Agreement Reforms

4.1 Additional Working Hours

Revised arrangements for the use of additional working hours under the Haddington Road Agreement for the Education and Training Sector have been put in place. The gross savings from implementation of the Haddington Road Agreement in the Education and Training sector were agreed with D/PER and have been built into the Education VOTE figure for 2014 and 2015.

4.1.1 Utilisation of additional hours in teaching (60,500 teachers)

The most significant measure was on the teaching side where the additional hours are utilised entirely to amend the existing supervision and substitution scheme. Additional hours are required from teachers under the supervision and substitution scheme and in addition to this payments under the scheme were discontinued with effect from the commencement of the 2013/14 school year giving an annual saving of c. €116M per annum for the lifetime of the Agreement.

4.1.2 Review in relation to additional hours for Special Needs Assistants (10,965 SNAs)

Under the terms of the *Public Service Agreement 2010-2014*, discussions took place that led to agreement on changed attendance arrangements for Special Needs Assistants (SNAs) that give schools the option of an additional two hours working time per week from each SNA. These new attendance arrangements are the subject of a LRC review in order to assess if the additional hours are being utilised in the most effective and appropriate manner and in order to achieve agreement on any changes deemed necessary in terms of the arrangement agreed for teachers. This review is ongoing under the auspices of the LRC.

4.1.3 Use of additional hours by third level lecturers (9,000) and non-academic staff (8,500)

Increased productivity from the additional time being delivered by the staff in third level institutions is being utilised to manage workloads and backlogs and maintain service delivery. Measures implemented include elimination of time off for church holidays, reduced extra weighting for evening lecturing, working an additional 78 hours per annum, reduction of fees for examination marking payments etc. On the non-academic staff side a reduction in the reliance on overtime will provide savings of €1.2m per annum. This is set in the context of increasing volumes of business and falling staff numbers for more than five years.

Implementation of these measures in the Education sector is complete. Reduction in the number of personnel required in third level Institutions to reflect the additional time now being delivered by all staff in the sector will yield a further €5m in both 2015 and 2016. This measure may necessitate a voluntary redundancy (VR) package or other such measure if staff numbers do not reduce naturally over time. However, at the moment the requisite savings associated with these measures are being delivered and have been built into the Education VOTE figure for 2014 and 2015.

4.1.4 Other staff (5,500), including Civil Service (1,500)

Other staff (administrative, management, support, research and others) are required to work additional time. Because the overwhelming majority of posts in question are subject to a strict moratorium on replacement, the scope for making savings on recruitments and appointments is negligible. For the most part, employers in the sector are using this additional time to manage workloads and backlogs and maintain service delivery in a context in which they have had increasing volumes of business and falling staff numbers for more than five years. No directly quantifiable savings can be attributed specifically to this additional time as the benefits will find expression in increased service enhancements and productivity rather than in direct cost savings.

DES is using the additional time to manage workloads, backlogs, maintain service delivery due to ECF restrictions and pay and conditions changes from Haddington Road Agreement, reduction in overtime costs (20%) and to undertake a review of Business Process Improvement projects in various areas of the Department.

4.2 Workforce restructuring

The HRA outlines that each sector will bring forward proposals for grade rationalisation with a view to restructuring grades in each sector by 2014; and develop and implement proposals to further reduce management numbers by increasing the span of control (ratio of staff to management) across all management and supervisory grades where appropriate.

4.2.1 Proposal for grade rationalisation

Work to-date on implementing the HRA in the Education sector has focused on implementing the key financial savings and structural work adjustments which under-pin the Agreement especially in light of the difficulties that were initially encountered on the teaching side due to the initial adverse ballot results.

Preliminary scoping work on grade rationalisation has commenced. This work has been done in conjunction with management representatives for the various employers that come under the remit of the Department. This initial work indicates that in order to ensure a level of consistency and proportionality across the public sector this work may require a central public service wide focus.

4.2.2 Further reduction in management numbers

Preliminary scoping work has been conducted in the education sector. However, given the cross-sectoral nature of the issue, plans will need to be advanced on a public service wide level, as any one sector will not be able to advance such proposals in isolation from other sectors. Proposals will need to be developed and agreed centrally, in conjunction with sectoral input. Our Department continues to monitor central progress in relation to this matter and liaise as appropriate with other sectors and Government Departments.

4.3 Redeployment

Existing redeployment schemes for teachers (primary and post primary) and non-academic grades in the Education and Training sector are continuing to operate satisfactorily. 3,551 staff redeployed (or took voluntary redundancy) in the sector in the period 2011 to November 2014. Following implementation of the HRA supplementary assignment arrangement have been put in place for SNAs. Redeployment arrangements for academic staff in the Institutes of Technology were introduced during 2014. Redeployment arrangements for academic staff in the Universities will be progressed if deemed appropriate and necessary during 2015. (There are no current surplus academic staff in the University sector).

4.4 Flexitime

New flexitime arrangements have been implemented with effect from 1 July 2013.

4.5 Work-sharing

New work sharing arrangements have been implemented with effect from 1 July 2013 including the stipulation that no future arrangement should be less than 50% of full time working hours.

4.6 Performance Management

4.6.1 Performance Management Systems are to be adapted in accordance with the relevant provisions of the HRA for Universities, Institutes of Technology and the ETBs during 2015.

4.6.2 In the DES, PMDS Calibration was introduced for Principal Officers and Assistant Principal Officers during 2014. PMDS is now under review by the Department of Public Expenditure and Reform in the context of the Civil Service Renewal Plan.

4.7 Sector Specific Measures from the appendices to the HRA

4.7.1 Expert Group (fixed-term/part-time employment in lecturing)

The Haddington Road Agreement outlined that an Expert Group would be established to consider and report on the level of fixed-term and part-time employment in lecturing, having regard to the importance for lecturers of employment stability and security and taking account of system and institution needs. The independent chair of this Expert Group has been appointed and the work of the group has commenced. As the group is chaired independently the Department does not wish to impose a time-scale on the working of the Group, nor seek to pre-empt the outcome of the group.

4.7.2 Expert Group (fixed-term/part-time employment in teaching)

The report of the expert group on fixed-term and part-time employment in teaching was published in September 2014. Implementation of this report is a key element of the Haddington Road Agreement and the Department is committed to putting in place arrangements to implement the report with effect from September 2015, following early engagement with the education partners. To this end, draft circulars have issued to representatives of both school management and teachers with a view to publication early in 2015.

4.7.3 Adult Education Tutors

Issues in relation to contracts for Adult Education Tutors were raised by the Union side during the talks leading up to the Haddington Road Agreement. It was agreed that these issues would be examined under the auspices of the LRC. This process has been progressed and a formal response from the Unions to the draft template document circulated in 2014 is due by mid-January. Further meetings of the parties are scheduled for 2015.

4.7.4 Subject to a response from the Government Legislative Committee the Universities (Amendment) Bill, to ensure compliance with government guidelines on remuneration, allowances, pensions and staffing numbers in the University Sector, will be published Q2 2015.

Appendix 1

